From Risk to Assets: A Strength-Based Developmental Approach to Indigenous Social Determinants of Health among Indigenous Youth

Charlotte Sumpf, Deenah Wright, Victoria Stillitano, Turna Hortoglu, Tasmia Hai & Jacob A. Burack
Department of Educational & Counselling Psychology, McGill University

McGill Youth Study Team

BACKGROUND

- Social Determinants of Health (SDOH) conceptualize health and development as shaped by social and structural conditions such as education, income, social class, gender, and race (WHO, 2010)
- The SDOH framework is largely developed from a Western epistemological perspective and emphasizes cumulative risks
- Indigenous scholars have highlighted a need specifically for an Indigenous Determinants of Health (ISDOH) framework, defined as "Indigenous knowledge and ways of being and doing that have kept communities' health well since inception" (Carroll et al., 2022)

Typology of Social Determinants (Carroll et al. 2022)

STRUCTURAL DETERMINANTS
Education - Income - Ethnicity

SHARED INDIGENOUS DETERMINANTS
land-based worldviews - collective wellbeing

COMMUNITY-SPECIFIC INDIGENOUS DETERMINANTS
History - multigenerational networks

OBJECTIVES

1. Examine culturally grounded ISDOH as promotive developmental processes in youth.
2. Situate community-specific determinants of health within multilevel ISDOH frameworks, to advance the theoretical integration between ISDOH and developmental frameworks.

METHOD

- almost 30 years of community engaged research among schools, Indigenous communities, and the McGill Youth Study Team (MYST)
- 6 published studies as developmental case studies
  - (Flanagan et al., 2010; Burack et al., 2013; Fryberg et al, 2013; Blacklock et al, 2020; Reynolds et al, 2024a; Reynolds et al, 2024b)
- focus on recurring promotive processes among the youth

KEY FINDINGS

Synthesized Evidence Across Studies

Cultural Identity
- Lower internalizing symptoms
- Less physical and relational aggression
- Lower substance use
- Higher academic achievement

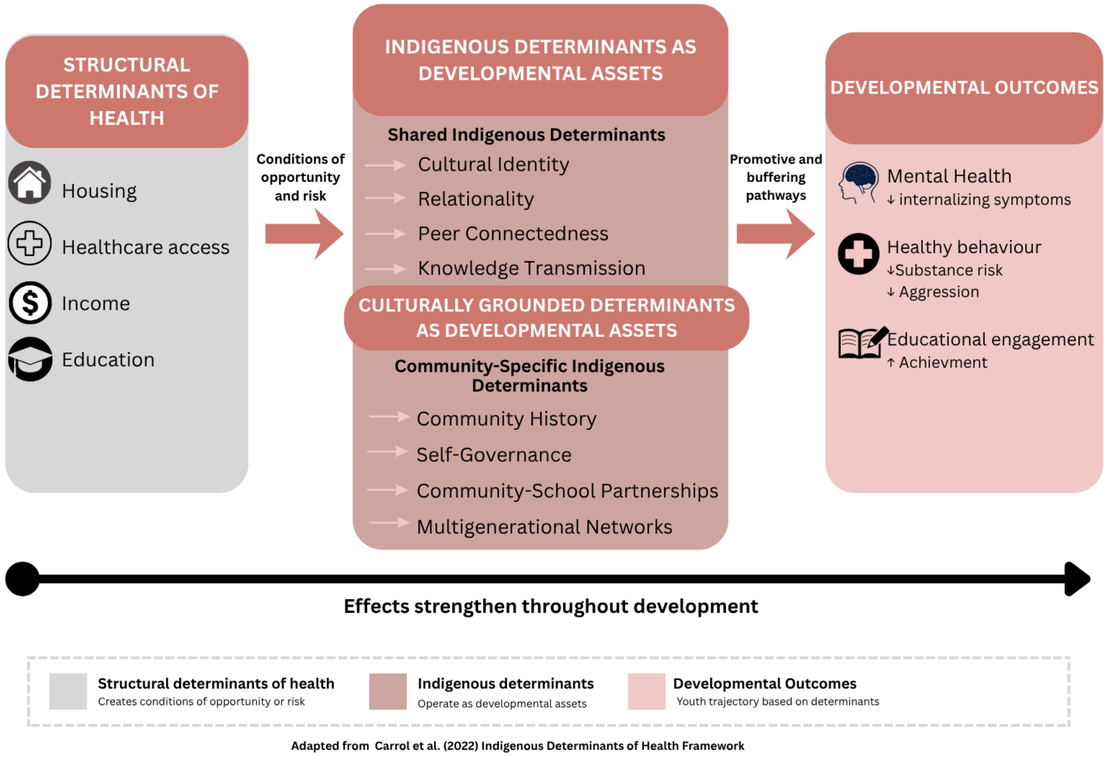
Peer Connectedness
- More academic achievement
- Having non-using peers can lead to protective substance-related beliefs and lower use

Dual Identity
- Buffers academic risk
- Alignment of indigenous values and school environment supports achievement

Traditions and Cultural Practices
- Lower physical and relational aggression

Culturally Grounded Determinants as Developmental Assets

An Integrative Strengths-Based Model for Indigenous Youth Development



Adapted from Carrol et al. (2022) Indigenous Determinants of Health Framework

SDOH: Social determinants shape exposure to structural and environmental risk
→ Risk is contextual, not deterministic

ISDOH: Indigenous determinants operate through active relational and cultural processes
→ Culture functions as a developmental mechanism

Community-Specific ISDOH: Resilience emerges through locally grounded knowledge, relationships, and adaptive practices
→ Development is culturally situated and non-uniform across communities

Integrated Developmental Systems: SDOH and ISDOH dynamically transact across developmental contexts
→ Development is systemic, relational, and culturally embedded

DISCUSSION

- Shift from deficit-oriented frameworks toward strength-based developmental systems models
- Culture, kinship, and relationality operate as core developmental mechanisms that shape pathways of wellbeing across domains
- Effective approaches to youth wellbeing must address BOTH:
  - Indigenous strengths, governance, and relational systems (ISDOH)
  - Structural inequities (SDOH)

→ Community-specific, culturally grounded approaches are essential, as wellbeing emerges through locally situated developmental systems rather than universalized models.

SOURCES

CONTACT

charlotte.sumpf@mail.mcgill.ca